



DATE: August 22, 2025

TO: Congressman Sam Graves, Chairman
Committee On Transportation and Infrastructure
2165 Rayburn House Office Building
Washington, DC 20515-6256

SUBJECT: NHMA Comments on Fixing Emergency Management for Americans (FEMA) Act of 2025 (H.R. 4669)

The National Hazard Mitigation Association (NHMA) is a non-profit volunteer organization dedicated to reducing the impacts of natural hazards that become disasters and supporting safe and sustainable infrastructure and community resilience. We provide practical advice, assistance, and resources to those involved in disaster risk reduction and community resilience strategies. NHMA serves as a respected voice in hazard mitigation, recovery, resilience, and climate adaptation policy both in the United States and worldwide.

BILL COMMENTS

Fixing Emergency Management for Americans (FEMA) Act of 2025 (H.R. 4669)

NATIONAL HAZARD MITIGATION ASSOCIATION

I. GENERAL COMMENTS

The National Hazard Mitigation Association (NHMA) supports the intent of H.R. 4669 to modernize FEMA and improve disaster response and mitigation. However, we recommend the following suggestions to help clarify and refine the goals of the Bill.



II. SPECIFIC COMMENTS

Division A

Title I – Establishment of FEMA

Section 11. Establishment of independent agency.

NHMA supports the re-establishment of FEMA as an independent agency. Consistent with this change, we feel it is an opportunity to also evaluate the regional structure of FEMA to address variability of disaster risk, opportunities of integration, and establishment of policy and operational consistency. We recommend that the Bill add language requesting FEMA to re-evaluate its regional structure and boundaries and based on that evaluation, develop a new regional structure to optimize FEMA's mission and support to the individual States and provide a report back to Congress within 180 days of the Bill's passage.

Division B

Title I – Public Assistance Reforms

Section 101. Rebuilding Public Infrastructure

(b) Grant Requirements, Sub-Section (1), Page 47, Line 23 – Sub-Section (8), Page 52, Line 12

NHMA strongly supports the fast estimation process for Public Assistance (PA) projects, especially the inclusion of mitigation measures and direct grants for repair of public facilities. This will streamline recovery and promote resilience but should include consideration and requirements with third-party insurance and mitigation requirements to avoid repeated losses.

(c) Funding, Sub-Section (2), Page 55, Line 10

NHMA recommends incentivizing State and local government such that FEMA only pay for a PA project once unless the subrecipient demonstrates Section 406 mitigation efforts including future coverage of insured losses.

Section 104. Federal Permitting Improvement

(a) In General, Sub-Section (1), Page 72, Line 3

NHMA supports streamlining federal permitting but urges inclusion of Sections 203 and 404 mitigation in the reforms. Post-disaster mitigation is not included as a major federal action as described in Line 5 (repair, restoration, reconstruction, or replacement) which should allow mitigation improvements to the facility.



Section 108. Disaster Management Costs Modernization

(c) Use of Excess Funds for Management Costs, Sub-Section (3), Page 99, Line 6

NHMA supports the modernization of disaster management costs. Allowing excess management funds to be used across open disasters addresses a long-standing stakeholder concern.

Title II – Individual Assistance Reforms

Section 207. Direct Assistance

(a) In General, Sub-Section (2), Page 135, Line 19

NHMA supports reforms that encourage preparedness and third-party insurance for homeowners. Line 23. We endorse the eligibility of hazard mitigation measures for private residences.

Title III – Mitigation Reforms

Section 301. Preapproved Project Mitigation Plans

(f) Preapproved Project Mitigation Plans, Sub-Section (5), Page 148, Line 19

NHMA believes the peer review process for mitigation grants is cumbersome due to project complexity, high costs, and unreliable results. We recommend adopting an action planning or intended use planning model instead, deemed successful in other federal programs (e.g., Department of Transportation).

Section 308. Study and Report on Mitigation Benefits

(a) In General, Page 169, Line 6

NHMA supports the sense of Congress statement in Sec. 308 for a review of mitigation benefits. It reinforces the importance of proactive risk reduction, measurement of outcomes, and federal leadership in resilience.

Additional Recommendations:

- A. NHMA is encouraged by the Committee’s intent to streamline pre- and post-disaster mitigation project approvals and funding. We suggest combining the provisions of Sections 404 and 203 in that regard.



- B. NHMA understands and supports the Bill's intent regarding setting of the Discount Rate for federal funding of eligible mitigation projects. Our recommendation is to consider language which permits adjustments to the Discount Rate to better enable long-term benefits and return on the federal investment.
- C. NHMA recommends creating a funding mechanism to support annual State mitigation planning needs to include all mitigation programs for example Sections 203, 404, Flood Mitigation Assistance (FMA) Grant Program, Safeguarding Tomorrow through Ongoing Risk Mitigation (STORM) Act, and others.
- D. NHMA recommends allowing the combining of mitigation funds from eligible programs for single projects.
- E. NHMA recommends language that streamlines approval of advanced construction, that enables efficient implementation of mitigation measures post disaster.

III. CONCLUDING REMARKS

NHMA supports the overall direction of H.R. 4669 and believes that with targeted amendments, the bill can significantly improve FEMA's effectiveness in disaster response, recovery, and mitigation management. We urge Congress to consider these recommendations to ensure the bill meets its full potential to save lives, protect assets, and bolster economies.

Sincerely,

National Hazard Mitigation Association Executive Committee

Brandy Bones
NHMA President

Caroline Cunningham, AICP, CFM, PMP
NHMA Vice President

Michael Sprayberry
NHMA Secretary

Grace Olenzak, EIT
NHMA Treasurer